

Angela Merrill

ENGL 225 Shakespeare: Beyond Tragedy

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Family Trees and the Danger of Sleep: Trunks in *Cymbeline*

Cymbeline contains some of Shakespeare's more unsettling plots, performed by the various men seeking to control and use innocent Innogen. One of the most memorable schemes is Giacomo's plot to rig his bet with Innogen's husband Posthumus by sneaking into her bedroom via a trunk and gathering enough data to falsely imply her infidelity (2.2). Cloten's plot is similarly unmissable: his goal of beheading Posthumus and assaulting Innogen while dressed in Posthumus' clothes ends in his own beheading. Innogen, waking from a drug-induced coma, mistakes Cloten's headless body for Posthumus, then for Posthumus' corpse. The Roman general Lucius encounters her in mourning and comments, "...Soft, ho, what trunk is here / Without his top?" (4.2.429-430).

Curiously, these two plots are united by the term *trunk*. At first glance, the usages of the term seem completely unrelated; the meanings and contexts are so different, it could just be instances of a homophone. However, when looking at the broader context of each scene, similarities arise. Although the two scenes seem unrelated, the fact that both Giacomo and Cloten assume the form of a "trunk" and trick Innogen in her sleep adds nuance to the characterizations and relationship of Innogen and Posthumus.

Despite the physical differences between a box and a headless body, both meanings of *trunk* derive from trees. According to the Oxford English Dictionary, a headless human *trunk* was adapted from the earlier sense of a *tree-trunk*, from which storage *trunks* were supposedly

carved (“Trunk, n.”). Following this tree imagery leads us to Cymbeline’s prophecy in the final act, as explained by the Soothsayer:

The lofty cedar, royal Cymbeline,
Personates thee; and thy lopped branches point
Thy two sons forth, who, by Belarius stol’n,
For many years thought dead, are now revived,
To the majestic cedar joined. (5.4.552-556)

Although the concept of a family tree is common, the fact that Shakespeare explicitly included the metaphor within the play allows us to expand upon the other instances of trees in *Cymbeline*. In this world, the branches of a tree are associated with children, which makes the roots parents, and dead family members break off of the main tree. Thus, because Innogen and Posthumus have no children, and no one can “delve [Posthumus] to the root” (1.1.28), Posthumus’ family tree is merely a trunk. Just as Cymbeline is a lofty cedar, Posthumus is a topless, rootless trunk. This metaphor is supported by Cloten’s experience (passing as Posthumus while being a headless trunk) and could smooth out the confusion of Innogen readily allowing Giacomo to store his things in her room despite him greatly offending her: Giacomo wants to store his and Posthumus’ trunk; Posthumus is a trunk; Posthumus would be allowed in his wife’s bedchambers; the trunk can be allowed in.

The fact that Posthumus is a trunk would then also add nuance to the concept of *clipping*. At Innogen and Posthumus’ reunion in the last scene of the play, Innogen, still disguised as a boy, runs to Posthumus to embrace him, but he doesn’t recognize her and hits her. Later, the Soothsayer describes the interaction: “this most constant wife, who even now, [...] / Unknown to you, unsought, were clipped about” (5.4.450-453). This line is ambiguous, because the word *clipped* can mean both to embrace (“Clip, n. (1)”) and to cut (“Clip, v. (2)”). Posthumus has a long history of family tree being pruned. However, in this moment, Innogen reclaims the word

clip by embracing her husband, accepting his unnoble (rootless) background in spite of the interference from Cymbeline, Giacamo, the Queen, and Cloten.

The next question to ask: what is the importance of Innogen being asleep during Giacomo and Cloten's manipulations? Throughout the play, Innogen's love is strongly tied to her vision. As early as Act 1, she links her constancy with her sight, as she thinks of Posthumus being banished and claims, "I would have broke mine eye-strings, cracked them, but / To look upon him till the diminution / Of space had pointed him sharp as my needle" (1.3.17-19). In the final scene, once the royal family (sans Queen and Cloten) is reunited, Cymbeline describes how Innogen "throws her eye / On [Posthumus], her brothers, [Cymbeline], her master, hitting / Each object with a joy" (5.4.394-398). In both of these scenes, Innogen's eyes manifest her affection. Thus, in order for Innogen to be manipulated, her vision must be taken away from her—which is easiest done with sleep. This connects to the fact that Pisanio, who is never swayed from his sense of justice, does not sleep between being told to kill Innogen and hiding her as a boy:

PISANIO. O gracious lady,
 Since I received command to do this business
 I have not slept one wink.
 INNOGEN. Do't, and to bed then.
 PISANIO. I'll wake mine eyeballs out first. (3.4.97-101)

Just like Innogen, Pisanio grounds his sanity and loyalty in his eyes. Although this exchange is meant to focus on his inability to find peace with himself if he were to kill Innogen, the fact that he does not sleep and does not get led astray by Posthumus supports the deep connection within this text between sight, consciousness, and autonomy. This theme is similarly played with in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, where "The juice of [a flower] on sleeping eye-lids laid / Will make or man or woman madly dote / Upon the next live creature that it sees" (2.1.542-544). Sleep

leads dreamers astray. When Innogen fully wakes up, she can utilize whatever power she has to uphold her morals, but in her sleep, she cannot tell the men no.

Following the term *trunk* reveals the similarities between Cloten and Giacomo's attacks on Innogen. Their successes in disrupting her relationship with Posthumus demonstrate the dynamic between the married couple, including how Posthumus is defined by his family and Innogen is defined by her sight. They complement each other (she is his "top"), and thus, "his virtue / By her election may be truly read, / What kind of man he is" (1.1.52-54).

Further analysis could include how sleep and death are conflated within the play. For example, during Innogen's coma, her brothers move her body to a suitably green grave, a scene that presents a more innocent version of men manipulating her body in her sleep. Even after she wakes up, Lucius is unable to determine whether she is alive. Trunks without their branches and roots are unable to live (as demonstrated by Cloten), so perhaps the bond between Innogen and Posthumus is forged between their mutual connection to death. In any case, their bond (though sometimes questionable) is revealed through the attacks from Giacomo and Cloten.

Works Cited

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